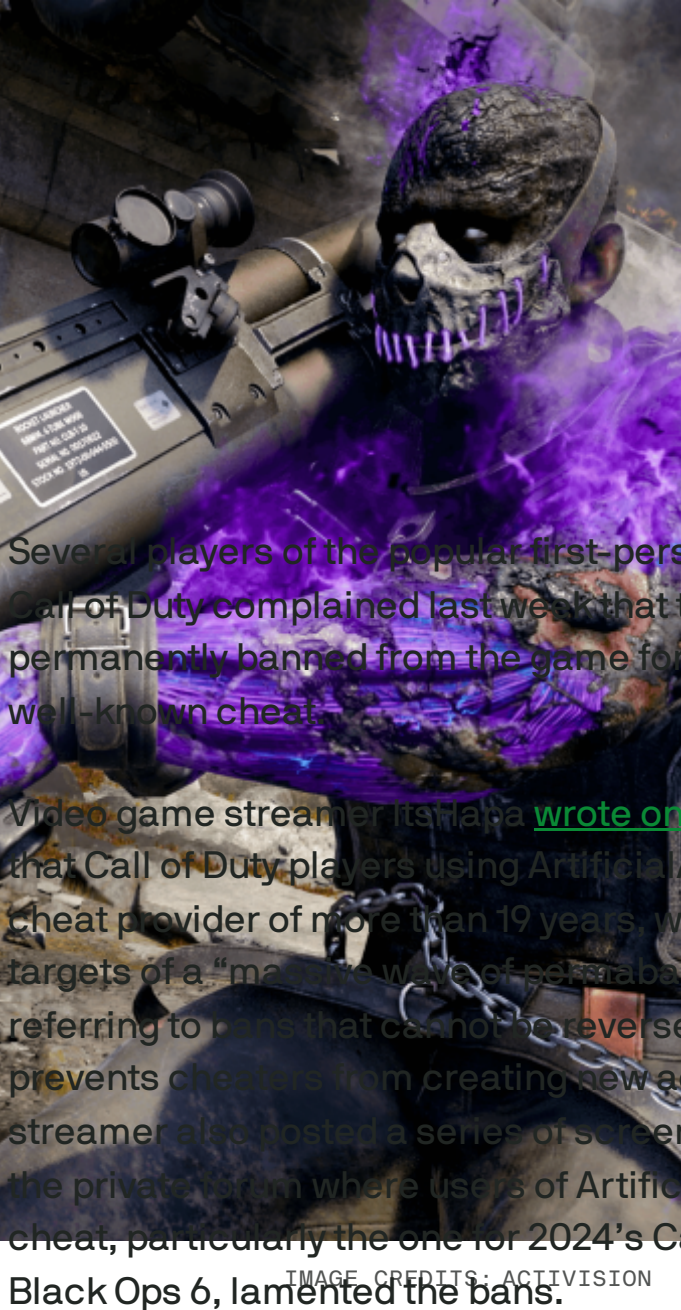


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SECURITY



Call of Duty cheaters complain after Activision launches new wave of mass-bans



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 9:59 AM PDT · July 16, 2025

Several players of the popular first-person shooter Call of Duty complained last week that they were permanently banned from the game for using a well-known cheat.

Video game streamer ItsyMitsy [wrote on X](#) last week that Call of Duty players using Artificial Aiming, a cheat provider of more than 19 years, were the targets of a “massive wave of permabans,” referring to bans that cannot be reversed, which prevents cheaters from creating new accounts. The streamer also posted a series of screenshots from the private forum where users of Artificial Aiming’s cheat, particularly the one for 2024’s Call of Duty: Black Ops 6, lamented the bans.

IMAGE CREDITS: ACTIVISION

“It’s been a long run. [Good game] all,” wrote one user.

“Lost both my main accounts today, one was almost 4 years old with mastery camos and all... think I am done with [Call of Duty].... risk we all took,” said another.

“It’s done for me [I’m] leaving this,” one complained.

“Same 😞,” added another player.

Neil Wood, a spokesperson for Activision, the video game publisher behind the Call of Duty series, confirmed to TechCrunch that there was a round of

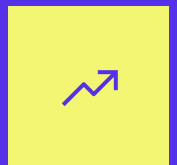
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account bans, and not just against users of the ArtificialAiming cheat. Wood declined to specify how many players were hit by the wave. In the past, these ban waves have hit hundreds of thousands of players at a time.

“Our latest enforcement efforts disrupted operations from multiple cheat vendors, disabling their tools and issuing bans to their users. We remain committed to pursuing those who threaten our community — cheaters, cheat makers, and anyone undermining the fair play experience,” read Activision’s statement.

Contact Us

Do you develop cheats, hack video games, or work in anti-cheat? We’d love to hear from you. From a non-work device and network, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#).

A person with knowledge of the cheating scene told TechCrunch that ArtificialAiming is a large and storied cheat provider, but that their cheats have been increasingly detected in recent years.

In a forum post from 2021, someone who appears to be a staffer at ArtificialAiming reflected about their then-14 years working at the cheat provider and proclaimed that “cheaters won,” as video game companies had to resort to spending millions of dollars to battle cheaters.

“It seems like there is not a single day where anti-cheaters are out there trying to rustle our jimmies. Well the fact that there still are hundreds of thousands of cheaters out there and a lot of them

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coming from ArtificialAiming, means that we're not defeated yet," they wrote.

Video game cheats can be a huge business. In 2021, Chinese police [arrested a group of people](#) who worked for what the authorities claimed was the "world's largest" video game cheating ring for the popular shooter "PUBG Mobile." The owner and founder of that cheat software [told me at the time that he netted at least \\$77 million](#) from developing cheats. [Other](#) cheat developers have claimed million-dollar earnings, or at least [enough to not have to work](#) for years. Others have had to [pay back millions of dollars](#) to video game companies after they were successfully sued.

In the last few years, in response to the growing popularity and sophistication of video game cheats, [companies have beefed up their anti-cheat teams](#) and technologies, launching anti-cheat systems that run at the [kernel level](#), giving the gaming companies visibility into virtually everything that runs on the computer.

Activision [launched](#) its kernel-level anti-cheat system Ricochet in 2021, following in the footsteps of other gaming giants, such as Riot Games, which released [its own kernel-level system](#) in 2020.

Topics: [Activision](#) [anti-cheat](#) [call of duty](#) [cheaters](#)
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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...



IMAGE CREDITS: ACTIVISION

SECURITY



Hacker says they banned ‘thousands’ of Call of Duty gamers by abusing anti-cheat flaw

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 8:50 AM PST · November 7, 2024

In October, video game giant Activision [said it had fixed a bug in its anti-cheat system](#) that affected “a small number of legitimate player accounts,” who were getting banned because of the bug.

In reality, according to the hacker who found the bug and was exploiting it, they were able to ban “thousands upon thousands” of Call of Duty players, who they essentially framed as cheaters.

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The hacker, who goes by Vizor, spoke to TechCrunch about the exploit, and told their side of the story.

“I could have done this for years and as long as I target random players and no one famous it would have gone without notice,” said Vizor, who added that it was “funny to abuse the exploit.”

TechCrunch was introduced to Vizor by a cheat developer called Zebleer, who is familiar with the Call of Duty hacking scene. Zebleer said he had been in touch with Vizor for months, and as such had knowledge of the exploit, which he said he saw Vizor using.

For years, [hackers have targeted online video games](#) to try to find flaws capable of installing and using cheats that give players an unfair advantage. Some cheat developers, such as Zebleer, sell their programs as a service, [sometimes making millions of dollars](#). In response, video game companies have been hiring cybersecurity specialists to develop and fine-tune their anti-cheat systems to catch and ban game cheaters. In 2021, Activision [released its Ricochet anti-cheat system](#), which runs at the [kernel level](#) in an attempt to make it even harder for cheat developers to get around it.

Vizor said they were able to find a unique way to exploit Ricochet, and use it against the players it was supposed to protect. The hacker realized Ricochet was using a list of specific hardcoded strings of text as “signatures” to detect hackers. For example, Vizor said, one of the strings was the words “Trigger Bot,” which refers to a type of cheat that automatically triggers a cheater’s weapon when their crosshair is over a target.

Vizor said they could simply send a private message — known as a “[whisper](#)” in the game — that included one of these hardcoded strings, such

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as “Trigger Bot,” and get the player they were messaging banned from the game.

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“I realized that Ricochet anti-cheat was likely scanning players’ devices for strings to determine who was a cheater or not. This is fairly normal to do but scanning this much memory space with just an ASCII string and banning off of that is extremely prone to false positives,” said Vizor, referring to

how the game was effectively scanning for banned keywords, regardless of context.

“The same day I found this, I got myself banned by sending a whisper message on Call of Duty to myself with one of the strings in the message contents,” said Vizor.

Contact Us

Do you develop or sell cheats? Or do you work on anti-cheat systems at a video game company? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

Vizor said that at one point they developed a script — “join a game, post a message, leave the game, join a new game, repeat repeat repeat,” as Vizor put it — that would run automatically and ban random players, which allowed them to go on vacation and still ban players. Vizor said that over the months that they were doing this, Activision would add new signatures to its anti-cheat system, which they would find soon after and use to ban players.

“I was most active with the trolling when [the] Ricochet anti-cheat team would add new string signatures. So if I check the [memory] region and see a new string, I will go crazy with it so they think they are detecting real cheaters,” said Vizor.

Activision did not respond to a request for comment.

A person who used to work at Activision, and still has knowledge of the work that the security and anti-cheat team do at the company, told

TechCrunch that Ricochet was scanning for certain signatures and “that may have been weaponized against the anti-cheat,” essentially the technique Vizor was exploiting.

“If you know what signature the anti-cheat is looking for, I find a mechanism to get those bytes in your game process and you get banned,” said the person, who asked to remain anonymous. “I can’t believe [Activision] are banning people on a memory scan of ‘trigger bot.’ That is so incredibly stupid. And they should have been protecting the signatures. That’s amateur hour.”

Apart from random players, Vizor said they targeted some well-known players, too. In the period of time Vizor was using the exploit, [some video game streamers](#) posted on X that they had been banned, and then [unbanned](#), once Activision fixed the bug.

The company was alerted of the existence of the bug when Zebleer [published details of the exploit](#) on X.

“It was nice to see it get fixed and see unbans,” said Vizor. “I had my fun.”

Topics: [Activision](#) [anti-cheat](#) [call of duty](#) [cheats](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: ACTIVISION / STEAM

SECURITY



Activision took down Call of Duty game after PC players hacked, says source

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 11:44 AM PDT · July 8, 2025

Games giant Activision took down Call of Duty: WWII due to hackers exploiting a flaw in a specific PC version of the game, which led to several players getting their computers hacked, TechCrunch has learned.

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Last week, Activision [announced](#) that it brought offline the Microsoft Store version of Call of Duty: WWII, a 2017 first-person shooter, as the company was investigating “reports of an issue,” without specifying what the issue was. The company had just launched that version of the game, also available on Game Pass, a subscription service that provides access to several games for a monthly fee.

A person with knowledge of Activision’s response told TechCrunch that the company took the game offline because of the hacks and while it works to patch the issue. TechCrunch is not naming the person, as they are not authorized to speak to the press.

[Several](#) video game [news outlets](#) reported on the story and noted that [several players complained](#) on [social media](#) that they had been hacked while playing the game. Until now, there had not been a confirmed link between the two events.

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— Wrioh (@wrioh75753) [July 3, 2025](#)

“The game is not safe to play on PC right now, there’s an RCE exploit,” a player wrote on Reddit last week, referring to a type of bug known as [remote code execution](#), which allows hackers the ability to plant malware capable of essentially taking control of a victim’s device.

The game for the Microsoft Store and Game Pass remains down at the time of publication, per [Activision’s status page](#).

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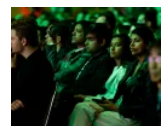
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Activision did not respond to multiple requests for comment.

The game publisher took down only the Microsoft Store and Game Pass version of Call of Duty: WWII because they were different versions of the game than listed on Steam and contained an old flaw that had been patched on other versions of the game, according to two sources with knowledge of the situation.

Contact Us

Do you have more information about these hacks? Or other video game hacks? From a non-work device and network, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#).

In the last couple of years, Activision has had to deal with several hacking incidents. In November 2024, a [hacker found a flaw in Call of Duty's anti-cheat system](#) that allowed them to ban thousands of legitimate gamers. Earlier in the year, the company investigated a hacking campaign targeting players with [infostealer malware](#), a type of malicious software designed to steal a victim's passwords. In 2023, [hackers used a self-spreading malware](#) — a computer worm — to hack Call of Duty: Modern Warfare players, [thanks to an unpatched years-old bug](#) in the game.

In recent times, some video game companies have beefed up their cybersecurity teams, as well as their [anti-cheat teams](#). Activision, however, has gone through [several rounds](#) of [layoffs](#) in the last few years, some of which have directly affected its cybersecurity teams.



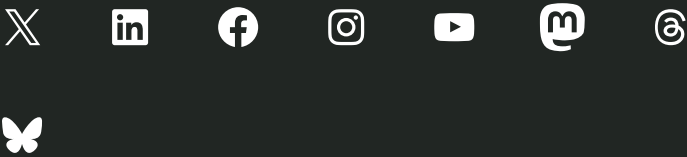
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